6.6.2 Preventive measures



Figure. 6.6 Lead coated aprons model.

- Radioactive materials should be kept in a thick walled lead container.
- Lead coated aprons and lead gloves should be used while working with hazardous radioactive materials.
- You should avoid eating while handling radioactive materials.
- The radioactive materials should be handled only by tongs or by a remote control device.
- Dosimeters should be worn by the users to check the level of radiation.

6.7 NUCLEAR REACTOR

A Nuclear reactor is a device in which the nuclear fission reaction takes place in a self-sustained and controlled manner to produce electricity. The first nuclear reactor was built in 1942 at Chicago, USA.

6.7.1 Types of nuclear reactors

Breeder reactor, fast breeder reactor, pressurized water reactor, pressurized heavy water reactor, boiling water reactor, water-cooled reactor, gas-cooled reactor, fusion reactor and thermal reactor are some types of nuclear reactors, which are used in different places world-wide.

6.7.2 Components of a nuclear reactors

The essential components of a nuclear reactor are (i) fuel, (ii) moderator, (iii) control rod, (iv) coolant and (v) protection wall.

i. **Fuel:** A fissile material is used as the fuel. The commonly used fuel material is uranium.
ii. **Moderator:** A moderator is used to slow down the high energy neutrons to provide slow neutrons. Graphite and heavy water are the commonly used moderators.
iii. **Control rod:** Control rods are used to control the number of neutrons in order to have sustained chain reaction. Mostly boron or cadmium rods are used as control rods. They absorb the neutrons.
iv. **Coolant:** A coolant is used to remove the heat produced in the reactor core, to produce steam. This steam is used to run a turbine in order to produce electricity. Water, air and helium are some of the coolants.
v. **Protection wall:** A thick concrete lead wall is built around the nuclear reactor in order to prevent the harmful radiations from escaping into the environment.

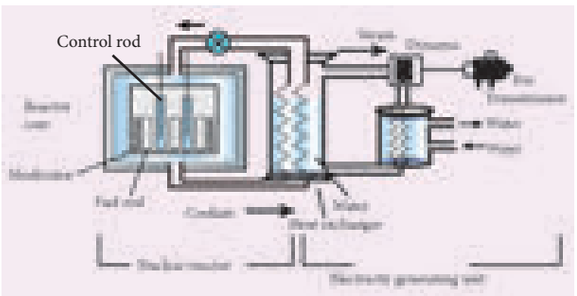


Figure 6.7 Schematic diagram of a nuclear reactor

6.7.3 Uses of a nuclear reactor

- Nuclear reactors are widely used in power generation.
- They are also used to produce radio isotopes, which are used in a variety of applications.
- Some reactors help us to do research in the field of nuclear physics.
- Breeder reactors are used to convert non-fissionable materials into fissionable materials.

6.7.4 Nuclear power plants in India

Indian Atomic Energy Commission (AEC) was established in August 1948 by the

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